

Papua New Guinea



A former Australian colony, Papua New Guinea (PNG) occupies the eastern section of the island of New Guinea and several other island groups. Much of the country is isolated.



GEOGRAPHY

Mountainous and forested mainland, with broad, swampy river valleys. 40 active volcanoes in the north. Around 600 outer islands.



CLIMATE

Hot and humid in lowlands, cooling toward highlands, where snow can fall on highest peaks.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Around 800 language groups and even more tribes. The main social distinction is between lowlanders, who have frequent contact with the outside world, and the very isolated, but increasingly threatened, highlanders. Great tensions exist between highland tribes, and vendettas can often last several generations. The island of Bougainville has been granted autonomy and promised an eventual referendum on independence.

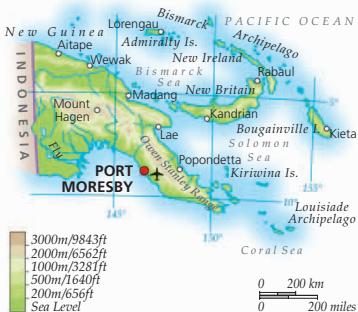


THE ECONOMY

Minerals: significant quantities of gold, copper, oil, and natural gas. High government spending almost led to national bankruptcy in 2002.



INSIGHT: PNG is home to the only known poisonous birds; contact with the feathers of some species of pitohui produces skin blisters



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Independent State of Papua New Guinea

DATE OF FORMATION: 1975

CAPITAL: Port Moresby

POPULATION: 6.73 million

TOTAL AREA: 178,703 sq. miles
(462,840 sq. km)

DENSITY: 39 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Pidgin English, Papuan, English*, Motu, c.800 native languages

RELIGIONS: Protestant 60%, Roman Catholic 37%, other 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Melanesian and mixed 100%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Kina = 100 toea